

ANI

SMALL COMFORT
TDP chief Naidu hands a relief cheque to a stampede victim's kin

ANDHRA PRADESH

FENCING MATCH

By Amarnath K. Menon

In the first fiat of the new year, Andhra Pradesh chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy banned road shows across the state—a move observers feel is targeted at stifling a resurgent Telugu Desam Party (TDP), its main rival in the state. The restrictions came after the death of 11 people in stampedes at two TDP rallies in Nellore and Guntur districts on December 28 and January 1, respectively. TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu had opted to lie low following the party's defeat in the 2019 assembly election. It's only in the latter half of 2022 that he became active again, and the two incidents, while tragic, also pointed to the kind of traction he was getting.

The state police have enforced the ban strictly by slapping notices and seizing TDP campaign vehicles. Naidu's plan for a road show from January 4-6 in his home constituency, Kuppam, was among the first casualties. The TDP supremo finally trekked through pockets of his constituency and even clambered atop a bus at Gudupalle to address supporters. "Jagan is fearful for the 2024 assembly election, that's why he is resorting to such actions. I will not rest until I put an end to his atrocious rule," says Naidu. He warned that clamping down on the rights of the Opposition will only intensify people's anger against the YSR Congress regime.

The YSRC counters that Naidu is indulging in "rowdy acts" to regain lost ground. "Had there been no deaths, there would have been no need to bring such rules," says S. Ramakrishna Reddy, YSRC general secretary and government advisor (public affairs).

A growing worry for the YSRC is the proposed padayatra of TDP leader Nara Lokesh, Naidu's son, from January 27. It will begin at Kuppam in Chittoor district and end at Ichchapuram in the northernmost coastal Srikakulam district. Lokesh will be walking 4,000 km in 400 days, which is 352 km and 59 days longer than Jagan's legendary padayatra that paved the way for his election victory in 2019. The latest order placing restrictions on vehicles has fuelled uncertainty, though.

JAGAN HAS BANNED RALLIES, BUT THE PADAYATRA PLAN BY TDP SCION NARA LOKESH IS A WORRY

The TDP is rallying support in case Jagan decides to call the assembly poll early. The YSRC is banking on the saturation coverage of its welfare/ populist policies to see it through. In 2019, the party had won 151 of the 175 assembly seats, reducing the TDP to just 23 seats. Actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party (JSP) had won one seat.

The TDP is also trying to patch up with the BJP. On January 16 at an all-party meeting called by the Election Commission of India, it took a U-turn on the EVM issue only to avoid antagonising the Union government. Earlier, it had been a strong advocate of banning EVMs and returning to the ballot system. Currently, a voter has to physically travel to the district where he or she is registered to vote, but in the proposed remote voting system, migrant voters won't have to anymore. The EC had made the suggestion in a letter to political parties on December 28 and called for a January 16 meeting to demonstrate a prototype of the system. It had asked the parties to forward their comments by January 31. While 16 opposition parties declared they will oppose the EC's multi-constituency remote voting machines, the TDP was among those who endorsed the idea. Despite these hiccups, Naidu is hoping to field a united opposition. Kalyan is already on board and if the BJP too signs up—as is most likely—Jagan could be up against his toughest political challenge yet. ■